Women in Video Games: What the Data Shows

Nov 6, 2026 · @Manon

Why this matters

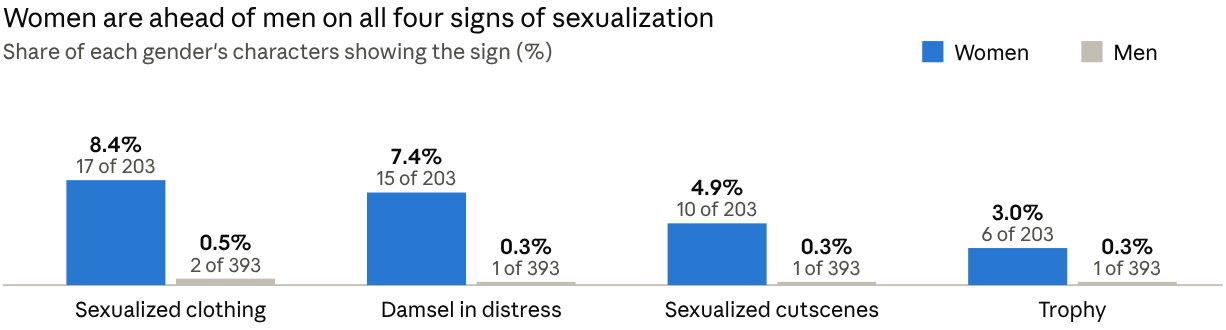
In successful video games, women are about a third of the characters, yet they are sexualized far more often, rarely cast as villains and under-represented as protagonists.

We analysed 64 top-selling or top-rated games (2012 to 2022, 637 characters) and compared 203 women with 393 men. The results describe successful games, not the whole industry.

Finding 1: women are sexualized about 14 times as often as men

29 of 203 women (14.3%) show at least one sign of sexualization, against 4 of 393 men (1.0%): about 14 times as often, in every role tier. The dataset checks four signs, and women lead on every one:

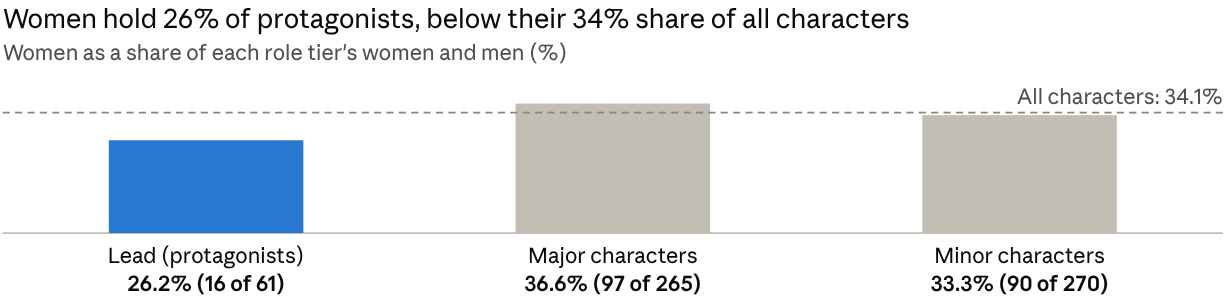
- **Sexualized clothing:** outfits that make no sense for the situation, or only women showing body areas men do not.
- **Damsel in distress:** a character who exists to be rescued by the hero.
- **Sexualized cutscenes:** scenes that dwell on body areas without need.
- **Trophy:** a character whose only purpose is to be won as a prize.



Notebook analysis, sexualization criteria by gender: 203 women, 393 men, 64 games

Finding 2: women fall short as protagonists, not as characters in general

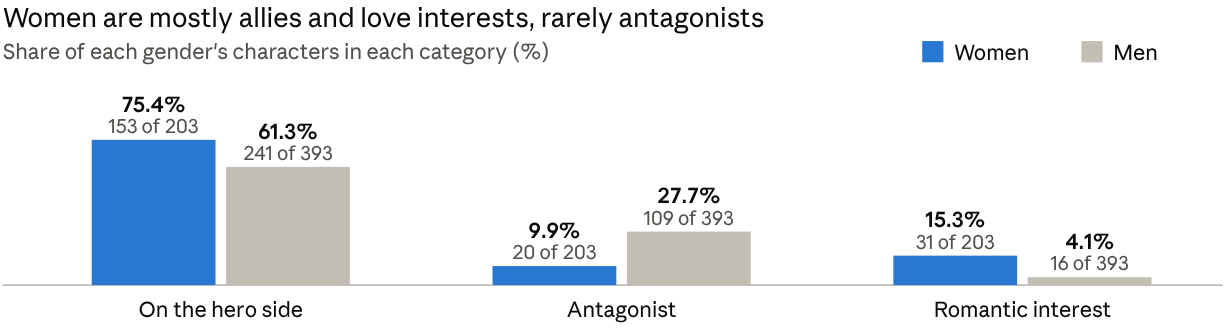
Women are 34% of all characters (203 of 596) but only 26% of protagonists (16 of 61). Among major characters (deuteragonists, main characters and main antagonists) they reach 37%, so the shortfall is at the lead role.



Notebook analysis, women and men by role tier: 596 characters, 64 games

Finding 3: women are mostly allies and love interests, rarely villains

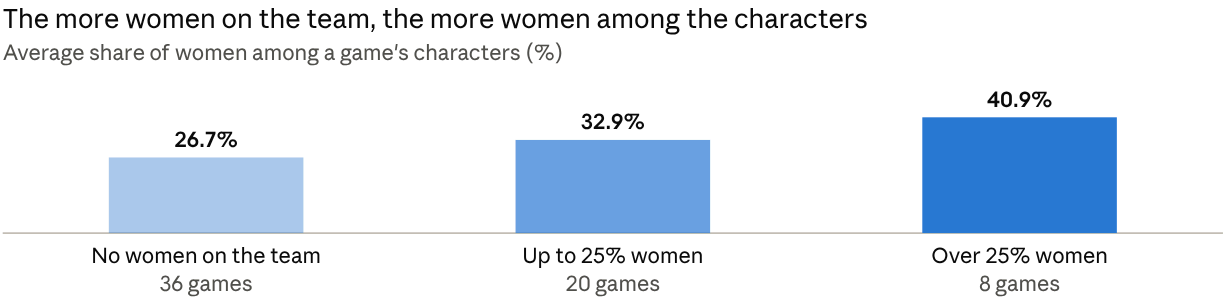
75% of women are on the hero's side, against 61% of men, and only 10% are antagonists, against 28%. Women are also two thirds of all romantic interests (31 of 47).



Notebook analysis, side and romantic interest by gender: 203 women, 393 men, 64 games

Finding 4: games with women on the team have more female characters

In the 36 games with no woman on the team, women are 27% of the characters. With women on the team it rises to 33%, and to 41% when they are over a quarter of the team. This is an association, not proof of cause.



Notebook analysis, share of women among characters by share of women in the team: 64 games

What studios can do

1. **Cast women as protagonists and as villains.** Women are 26% of protagonists and 15.5% of antagonists, against 34% of all characters. Matching their overall share would mean about five more women among these 61 protagonists.
2. **Stop defaulting women to the love interest and the helper.** Two thirds of romantic interests are women, and three quarters of women characters are on the hero's side.
3. **Remove the four signs of sexualization.** Use the four signs as a checklist in costume and cutscene reviews. Clothing and damsel plots show the widest gap.
4. **Build teams with women, and track the numbers.** Games with women on the team have more female characters. Publish each year the share of women among protagonists, antagonists and sexualized characters.

What the numbers can and cannot say

- **Successful games only.** 64 top-selling or top-rated titles from 2012 to 2022. Non-binary and custom characters (41) are too few to compare.
- **Small counts, patterns not causes.** Only 34 characters are sexualized, so read each percentage with its count.
- **Source.** Kaggle dataset Gender Representation in Video Games (Brisa Palomar, 2022).